

Co-Constructing the Future of Digital Intimacy

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Abstract

The Internet, artificial intelligence, and other emerging technologies have transformed the way humans can interact with each other and express romance, sex, and other forms of intimacy. Digital intimacy, including online dating, sexual/intimate content sharing, online sex work, and romantic chatbots, has grown ubiquitous. This can both be a source of great joy, such as when connecting remote partners and supporting sexual self-expression, and a source of harms, including but not limited to image-based sexual abuse, deep-fakes, location privacy violations, and technology-enabled intimate partner violence. As new technologies continue to transform digital intimacy, this workshop aims to create a sex-positive space for digital intimacy researchers as we imagine and build a world where everyone is able to safely engage in consensual intimate activities with dignity and agency.

CCS Concepts

• **Security and privacy** → **Human and societal aspects of security and privacy**; • **Human-centered computing** → **Human**

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computer interaction (HCI); Collaborative and social computing; • Social and professional topics → **Computing / technology policy**; • **Applied computing** → **Computer forensics; Law, social and behavioral sciences.**

Keywords

non-consensual image sharing, digital intimacy, sexting, romance, relationships, generative AI, social media, secure messaging

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1 Motivation

Using technology to create or facilitate sexual and/or romantic relationships both online and offline is a societal norm and of research interest. Scholars are working on topics such as online dating [20, 67, 68], sexual/intimate content sharing [28, 41], sex work [36], virtual reality (VR) dating [48, 49, 66], consent [69], and how digital intimacy technologies may work differently for gender and sexual minorities [16, 17, 67]. Researchers have also examined technologically mediated forms of sexual violence, such as intimate partner violence or surveillance [7, 55, 56] and image-based sexual abuse [57, 61]. As the research community grows, there is opportunity to discuss commonalities, surface research challenges, and collectively build resources for researchers and relevant communities. Given increasing legislative action to address harms [2, 8], researchers must work across disciplines to form new research

agendas, discuss best practices, and work towards collective advocacy. This workshop aims to create a sex-positive space for digital intimacy researchers as we imagine and build a world where everyone is able to safely engage in consensual intimate activities with dignity and agency.

We define digital intimacy broadly to bring together an expansive network of workshop attendees. For our purposes, digital intimacy is any technologically facilitated intimate or sexual interaction; positive or negative, consensual or nonconsensual. Examples of digital intimacy include, but are not limited to:

Technologically Facilitated Dating. Online dating is being used to connect potential sexual and romantic partners [12, 13, 49], and can aid relationship-building, sexual exploration, identity formation, friendship, and emotional support, particularly for LGBTQ+ users [14, 16, 17, 54]. At the same time, dating platforms can come with certain risks [25] like bias and discrimination [29], privacy tensions with location sharing [12], extortion scams [1], and disclosure of stigmatized gender and sexual identities [20]. Sexual violence persists in online dating apps not only through deliberate predation, but also through sexual consent practices: how users give and (perceive to) receive agreement to sexual activity. VR dating applications creates new opportunities for rich, immersive sexual experiences [66], but also further risk of accidental harm through misinterpreted consent [48, 68].

Relationships and Technology-Facilitated IPV. People in existing relationships may share various accounts and smart devices [31], leading to data privacy tensions [63]. In the context of abusive relationships, smartphones and other digital technologies can be used to by abusers to, surveil, harass and track intimate partners (IPV) [23, 62].

Generation of Sexually-Implicit and Explicit Media. Adults send and receive intimate media (e.g., nude, semi-nude videos and images) [59] in many types of relationships and through most technology that allows image/video sharing and storage [24, 26, 42]. This can be a healthy and joyful practice that increases relationship satisfaction [10, 19, 40, 52, 58]. However, digital sexual imagery is particularly vulnerable to abuse [44] (image-based sexual abuse or IBSA) through nonconsensual sharing and creation (and threats of both) of sexual/intimate media [38]. IBSA also disproportionately harms marginalized groups [11], and what content is considered harmful is culturally dependent [6, 47]. Sex workers, who are often excluded from conversations around IBSA, can face the additional harms of having their labor stolen and the risk of being outed when their content is nonconsensually distributed [60].

Sex Work. Sexual/intimate media creation and sharing can also be a form of labor. Particularly since the COVID-19 pandemic, more people have shifted from in-person to online sex work, providing benefits of increased physical safety, greater flexibility, and (for some) greater financial opportunities [27]. Sex workers also face stigmatization [5, 36, 37] and may manage multiple sources of digital risk.

Emerging Technologies for Sex. People report using AI companions to find emotional support, explore their sexuality, and reduce loneliness [32, 35]. Emerging technologies also include networked sex toys that can wirelessly connect long-distance lovers [21, 53], and virtual reality is being used for sex therapy and for immersive sexual experiences [34, 39]. These tools and apps may

collect very intimate data, leading to collection and usage concerns [50, 51, 53, 64]. Romantic AI chatbots also suffer from security and privacy flaws [46]. And while AI companions are new technology, gendered interactions harms still play out [33], and sex robots remain controversial [18]. Finally, perpetrators have used generative AI to create fake sexual imagery (deepfakes) without consent of victims, a form of sexual abuse [9, 22, 57].

2 Workshop Goals & Activities

Given the potential for both joy and and harm, there is a need for sex-positive spaces that center the ways technology can facilitate human relationships, aid self-discovery, aid sexual exploration, and create joy, while preventing harms. Given the interdisciplinary nature of the CSCW community, who research design of social computing systems or critically analyze such systems related to digital intimacy [3, 4, 15, 17, 20, 27–29, 43, 45, 48, 69], a CSCW workshop would foster connections amongst HCI researchers and practitioners and others working in this space: scholars in other disciplines, policy-makers, advocacy groups. The following details our vision and broader goals for the workshop.

- **Building ties within the community.** Six of the co-organizers previously co-hosted a half-day workshop at the Berkman Klein Center for Internet & Society at Harvard University called Designing Safe(r) Digital Intimacy [30]. This was a half-day workshop for students, but we received over 165 applications to attend from a range of backgrounds, including government regulators, industry professionals, and senior level researchers across disciplines. While we could not accommodate everyone at the time, we recognize we are a quickly growing community with a need to gather and share knowledge.
- **Explore open problems.** As digital components in social relationships enable new forms of both connection and abuse, we ask: how do we make technical interventions to prevent abuse in forms of technology we have been using for decades (e.g., dating apps, messaging apps, social media)? How can researchers address the growing risks that generative AI poses to the non-consensual creation of sexual/intimate content? How can we address harms while not building or regulating technology in a way that further stigmatizes or discourages healthy human sexual expression?
- **Bring outside research discipline perspectives to CSCW.** There are also scholars across other disciplines, such as sociology, psychology, gender and sexuality studies, and law, who have deep histories in studying issues related to digital intimacy. We want a variety of disciplines represented to incorporate such create dialogue on how computer scientists can learn from (and support) work in other fields.
- **Creating space to discuss research challenges.** Computer science has best practices on data collection that fail for intimate data given the stigmatized content and various social harms that can arise from such data collection. This workshop would provide an opportunity to discuss how to establish best practice for intimate data collection, and other ethical concerns. There is also room to explore new models

of data governance that are centered on the experiences of victim-survivors [65].

- **Destigmatize work in this field.** Research on sex, sex work, and other intimate topics can be stigmatized and isolating. By organizing this workshop, we hope to bring greater visibility to the CSCW researchers working on digital intimacy. We hope to create a sex-positive space for digital intimacy research that values agency, justice, inclusivity, consent, and harm reduction.

2.1 Workshop Schedule

Our workshop will consist of four main sessions (**lightning talks, a panel, and breakouts**) followed by a brief wrap-up session. We will solicit submissions for the lightning talk session within our call for participation and collect submissions through a participation questionnaire.

- **Lightning talks:** Selected speakers will give presentations on either published work or works-in-progress in two sessions. Within a session, a small group of speakers will give a brief talk. Then there will be a discussion period that allows participants to ask speakers their questions. The Q&A will be moderated by an organizer.
- **Speaker panel:** The organizers will curate a speaker panel of 3–5 people working on topics related to digital intimacy. The panel will consist of those involved in policy-making efforts, legal scholars, porn studies scholars, and others. Topics to explore include the challenges of procuring funding, how computer scientists can better support policy-making/advocacy efforts, and how researchers in other disciplines (e.g., psychology, sociology, gender & sexuality studies) approach researcher safety.
- **Breakout session:** During the workshop, we will have an open digital space in which participants can pitch different topics they are hoping to discuss with small groups. We offer this for participants to discuss and expand upon any ideas that may have formed through the course of the workshop. We also hope that this session may offer space for participants to discuss challenges that have arisen in their work, develop new project ideas, or discuss ways of supporting broader advocacy/policy-making efforts.
- **Wrap-up session:** During the wrap-up session we will bring the full groups of participants together to reflect on the activities of the day.

Following the workshop, we intend to publish any completed resources from the resource building session (e.g., a digital syllabus of academic work on digital intimacy). Participants will decide how to publish these digital assets and we will share the links to them on the workshop website.

2.2 Hybrid Workshop Plans

To make our workshop hybrid, we will designate a Zoom coordinator (one of the workshop organizers) who will be available during each session to monitor the Zoom chat technical issues. We emphasize that 6 of the workshop organizers previously organized a one-day hybrid workshop together and have experience managing the logistics that accompany enabling hybrid participation.

The lightning talks, keynote presentation, and panel discussion will all be hybrid. For these sessions, an organizer will take questions from in-person workshop participants and those joining on Zoom. During the breakout session, which will consist of two parallel events, participants will be asked to form small groups. To ease coordination, virtual participants and in-person participants will be split such that they may only form small groups with others in the same mode of participation. We will use Miro, an online collaborative vision board, for group activities. After the activities, we will reconvene as a group for a brief wrap-up session. During this wrap-up session, all participants will be involved in a joint activity.

2.3 Accessibility

It is important our workshop is accessible and allows for full participation from all attendees. Once we have finalized participants, we will survey them for accessibility requests. We will try to accommodate requests and note a notification deadline to tell participants if there is a request we cannot accommodate. At minimum, we will enable auto-captioning for virtual participants and for in-person participants, we will reserve seats near speakers, provide KN-95 respirators, and ensure microphones are always used for the hybrid non-small-group activities of the workshop.

3 Organizers

The organizers are all engaged in digital intimacy research and have published at CSCW as well as other HCI-adjacent conferences such as SOUPS and USENIX.

Chris Geeng is an assistant teaching professor at Northeastern University, Seattle Campus, in the Khoury College of Computer Science who studies security and privacy mitigations around online dating and intimate imagery.

Lucy Qin is postdoctoral fellow at Georgetown University. Her current research explores mitigation against IBSA while enabling safer intimate content sharing.

Allison McDonald is an Assistant Professor of Computing & Data Sciences at Boston University. Her expertise spans computer security and human-centered computing, with a focus on understanding and disrupting technology-enabled harms.

Amna Batool is a PhD candidate at the School of Information, University of Michigan, specializing in women's online privacy needs in a global context. By collaborating with NGOs and law enforcement agencies in South Asian communities, she explores how these abuses occur, the avenues victims use to seek help, and how online platforms and local agencies interact to address these issues.

Diana Freed is an Assistant Professor of Computer & Data Science at Brown University. Her current research includes a focus on human-centered security, privacy and policy aimed at addressing technology-facilitated intimate threats and image-based sexual abuse.

Oliver L. Haimson is an Assistant Professor at University of Michigan School of Information and author of *Trans Technologies* (MIT Press, 2025). His research focuses on envisioning and designing trans technologies, social media content moderation and

marginalized populations, and transgender people's experiences with social technologies.

Jevan Hutson is an Acting Assistant Professor of Law and Director of the Technology Law and Public Policy Clinic at the University of Washington School of Law. His current work focuses on sexual privacy and intimate computing, particularly the legal, ethical, and design aspects of intimate platforms and data.

Elissa M. Redmiles is the Clare Luce Booth Assistant Professor of Computer Science at Georgetown University. Her current work includes a focus on security and privacy and preventing sexual abuse for those engaged in digitally-mediated recreational and commercial intimacy.

Zahra Stardust is a porn studies scholar interested in the regulation of sexual cultures. Her first book *Indie Porn: Revolution, Regulation and Resistance* (Duke University Press, 2024) explores the clash between indie porn producers, governments and big tech. She is a Lecturer in Digital Communication at the Queensland University of Technology and an Affiliate at the Berkman Klein Center for Internet and Society.

Miranda Wei is a postdoctoral researcher at Princeton University. Their doctoral work investigates online help-seeking and giving for safety threats in interpersonal relationships, including image-based sexual abuse and synthetic nonconsensual explicit imagery.

Douglas Zytke is an Associate Professor and Director of Graduate Studies in the College of Innovation & Technology at the University of Michigan-Flint. His research uses consent as a lens to understand and design mitigative solutions for sexual harm, often in the context of online dating.

4 Participant Recruitment and Selection

Expected attendance. We anticipate 20-30 in-person attendees and around 10 virtual attendees.

Participant Recruitment. Organizers will disseminate the call for participation (see Appendix A) through their social media accounts, mailing lists, and directly contacting other colleagues.

Participant Selection. Participants will be asked to take a survey to indicate their interest in the workshop and relevant experience. Participants may submit a lightning talk with a talk abstract and a link to published work (if applicable). For unpublished works, participants will submit an abstract describing the talk. The co-organizers will review the survey responses and select the final group of attendees based on a background relevance.

5 Equipment and Supplies

Our workshop will require a minimal amount of materials: a screen and projector for displaying slides, microphones for speakers and for audience members (when asking questions). We will supply anything additional.

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A Call for Participation

As in most other facets of life, people have brought parts of their intimate and sexual relationships online. Research and design for digital sexual intimacy can support opportunities for stronger relationships, greater self-esteem, and sexual satisfaction. At the same time, new forms of digitally-mediated sexual abuse have arisen, driving a range of research on understanding, preventing, and remedying harms. While this area is growing rapidly, research across the spectrum of digital intimacy can be stigmatized and ethically challenging, making working in the space an isolating experience for many. Furthermore, as there are increasing moves to regulate technology used in perpetuating sexual violence, there is a need for researchers across discipline to work cooperatively to form research agendas, define best practices for work in this space, and work towards joint recommendations for collective advocacy.

Workshop goal: this **hybrid** workshop brings together scholars and practitioners across disciplines to create community and share expertise on the challenges of building, researching, and regulating intimate technologies. The workshop is aimed at researchers who have already done some work in the field, as our goals include sharing research challenges and agenda-setting.

- **Participation:** Please complete the survey at <https://futureofdigitalintimacy.github.io> to indicate your interest and experience. This will require submitting your name, a short biography, why you would like to attend the workshop, and what you hope to get from attending.
- **Talk Submission:** We are accepting submissions for lightning talks. In the same survey at <https://futureofdigitalintimacy.github.io>, please include an abstract and a link for published work. For work-in-progress, please submit an abstract, describing the content of a roughly 10-minute talk.

Responses will be reviewed by the workshop organizers. Upon acceptance, at least one author of each accepted talk must attend the workshop. The submissions will not be published—we will instead publish a list of talk abstracts and a summary of the workshop activities on our website. All participants must register for the workshop. For more information, visit: <https://futureofdigitalintimacy.github.io>